

A detailed illustration of a dwarf warrior with a beard and a red and black tunic, fighting a large, scaly dragon. The dwarf is holding a sword and looking up at the dragon's head, which is open in a roar. The scene is set in a dark, rocky cave with some green moss on the ground.

Unearthed Arcana: Less Death, More Danger!

By Jeffrey Ludwig

Illustration by Sam Wood

Axe-wielding orcs, fire-breathing dragons, and flesh-eating zombies are a few of the deadly adversaries that adventurers face on a daily basis. That they dare fight such foes at all is wonder enough, but more puzzling still is how heroes can walk away from such battles without a scratch. Oh, they might be bloodied for a round or two, or they might fall unconscious on the field of battle, but a few *inspiring words* and *Heal* checks later, the heroes are as good as new.

But what if they aren't as good as new?

The Injury deck presented here provides you with an optional system that lets the monsters give the heroes a little something to remember them by. Each Injury card describes a wound that goes beyond a mere loss of hit points to afflict a character in a lasting way; these injuries take more than a soothing word and a few minutes of rest to heal. Sticks and stones might break an adventurer's bones, but a sucking chest wound is nasty.

WHY USE INJURIES?

If you like an extra dose of grit in your game, the idea of persistent injuries probably appeals to you already. But if you want to have a softer touch with your

players, take a look at a few reasons to consider introducing them to the Injury deck.

Holding Life Dear

Players don't always act in their characters' best interests. For example, a fighter low on hit points ought to take cover to bandage wounds instead of staying in the fight, but the player might choose to have the fighter continue to attack each round instead, risking death. In such a case, the player might be depending on the healing that the party's cleric can provide. With the optional Injury deck, a character who drops to 0 hit points can sustain wounds that linger long after the battle is over. By using injuries as a consequence for falling in battle, a DM encourages a player to use his or her character's action points, healing options, and limited-use powers more aggressively to keep that character standing. A player might also change strategies to keep his or her character's hit points out of the territory where a single attack can kill the character.

An Alternative to Death

Heroes don't always walk away from battles. Sometimes a critical hit does them in, or they have an

unlucky death saving throw. Even the pluckiest players sober up at the prospect of sitting out the rest of the session while the group finds a way to revive fallen characters. Worse yet, untimely deaths can stop adventures in their tracks or derail entire plot lines.

Injuries can provide an alternative to character death, serving as a serious repercussion for “dying” while allowing players to get back in the game quickly. A party with injured characters might be better served returning to town to nurse its wounds, but if the need is pressing, adventurers can forge on with wounded characters better than it could with dead ones.

Although you can use injuries as an alternative to death, characters are not necessarily immortal. You might have a compelling narrative reason for letting a character die, or you might want to add injuries to the game while still allowing for the possibility that combat can be fatal. You might decide, for instance, that a character who is reduced to his or her negative bloodied value by a coup de grace is killed rather than injured. Injuries act as a kind of insurance against accidental death in combat, while still allowing your villains to dispatch adventurers as they see fit. And if the only way to destroy the *Eye of Vecna* is for the adventurer using it to jump into the flames of Moradin’s forge, it’s fair to stipulate that the character doing so is not going to walk away with only a major injury. Whatever your decision, the key is to communicate clearly to your players beforehand what circumstances, if any, might result in character death rather than injury.

A Final Consideration

If you’re thinking about adding the Injury deck to your bag of tricks, the first thing to consider is whether your players are game for it. Injuries can saddle characters with significant and lasting handicaps, and although some players appreciate the additional challenge, others might regard it as a form

of punishment. Knowing and communicating with your players is the key to making sure injuries add to, rather than detract from, fun at your table.

USING THE INJURY DECK

To use the Injury deck, print and cut out the cards at the end of this article. (You can print two or three copies to create a larger deck.) Each card represents a single injury and has two severities, minor and major.

At the start of an encounter, shuffle the Injury deck and place it face down on the table where the players can reach it. When a character sustains an injury, have the player draw the top card.

Sustaining an Injury

Three circumstances might cause a character to sustain an injury: dropping below 1 hit point, failing three death saving throws before taking a short rest or an extended rest, or taking damage that reduces his or her hit points to his or her bloodied value expressed as a negative number. (See “Dying and Death” in the *Rules Compendium* for the rules on character death.)

Minor and Major: The effects of injuries are spelled out on the Injury cards. A minor injury has the effect described in the “Minor” section. A major injury has the effect described in both the “Major”

section and the “Minor” section. For example, the Ruptured Spleen injury also includes the effects of Gut Wound (the minor injury on that card).

More than One Injury: A character can sustain only one injury per encounter but can have two or more injuries during an adventure (see “Multiple Injuries” below).

Dropping Below 1 Hit Point

When a character drops below 1 hit point, he or she risks sustaining an injury. At the end of an encounter, any character who dropped below 1 hit point during the encounter makes a saving throw. On a save, the character avoids injury. On a failure, the player draws a card from the Injury deck; the character suffers the minor injury on the card. If a character drops below 1 hit point multiple times during an encounter, the player still makes a single saving throw at the end of the encounter to determine whether he or she sustains a minor injury. If a character sustains a major injury during an encounter (see below), the player does not make this saving throw.

Failing Three Death Saving Throws

Any character who fails three death saving throws automatically sustains a major injury and does not die. After the character fails the third death saving throw, the player draws a card from the Injury deck, and suffers the major injury there. In addition, the character falls unconscious until the end of the encounter. At the end of the encounter, the character regains consciousness and has 1 hit point.

Falling to Your Negative Bloodied Value in Hit Points

As with failing three death saving throws, the character automatically sustains an injury after taking damage that reduces his or her current hit points to his or her bloodied value expressed as a negative number. The player draws a card from the Injury

DECK-BUILDING TIP

You can use spray adhesive to mount your printouts on card stock before cutting them for a more durable deck. Spare game cards and a glue stick work well too.

deck, and the character suffers the effect shown in the “Major” section. In addition, the character falls unconscious until the end of the encounter. At the end of the encounter, the character regains consciousness and has 1 hit point.

Multiple Injuries

Over the course of an adventure, a character might sustain more than one injury. If two or more injuries impose penalties on the same game statistic, the effects are cumulative.

Duplicate Injuries: If you are using an Injury deck that’s larger than one card of each type, a character cannot incur multiple instances of the same injury. If a character who has a minor injury sustains the same injury again, the player discards the duplicate card, and the severity of the injury increases to major. If the duplicated injury is major, the player discards the duplicate card and draws a new one.

VARIANT: FIGHTING THROUGH INJURIES

Injuries might be significant setbacks, but where adventurers differ from ordinary folk is in their determination to triumph in the face of adversity. This section presents two optional systems to allow characters to persevere despite injury: one general, the other more situational.

1. Push Past the Pain

Once per encounter per Injury card, an injured character can attempt to push past the pain as a free action to temporarily reduce the injury’s effect. Even if a character has multiple injuries, he or she can use this option only once per turn; the player decides which injury counts for the attempt.

Ignore Minor Injury: A character can briefly disregard the effect of a minor injury by making

a Constitution check or Charisma check (player’s choice) as a free action at the start of his or her turn. Use an easy DC of the character’s level. On a success, the injury has no effect that turn. The character can attempt to extend this benefit at the start of his or her next turn by making a second check, now with a moderate DC, and at the start of the following turn with a third check, now with a hard DC. The injury cannot be ignored further in following turns. If any of these checks fail, the character cannot attempt to disregard that Injury card again during the encounter.

Reduce Major Injury: A character can attempt to reduce the effect of a major injury to that of the corresponding minor injury; for example, temporarily reducing the effect of Crushed Hip to Gashed Thigh. The character must make a Constitution check or Charisma check (player’s choice) at the start of his or her turn. Use a moderate DC of the character’s level. On a success, the injury is reduced for that turn. The character can attempt to extend this benefit at the start of his or her next turn by making another check, but with a hard DC. The injury cannot be ignored further in following turns. If any of these checks fail, the character cannot attempt to reduce the effect of that Injury card again during the encounter.

2. Profit from Setbacks

Some characters thrive on challenges. Some players like to overcome steep obstacles. If your campaign caters to that sort of activity, consider using this option to allow characters to turn their wounds into opportunities.

Once per encounter per injury, if an injured character meets the trigger described in the text below for his or her injury location, he or she can attempt to turn the pain of the injury into a momentary advantage. The character makes a check as a free action using the indicated ability against an easy DC of the character’s level. On a success, the character benefits from the positive effect. On a failure, the character

suffers the negative effect. Even if a character has multiple injuries, he or she can use this option only once per turn.

Injury Card	Location
Concussion/Cracked Skull	Head
Cracked Rib/Sucking Chest Wound	Torso
Face Slash/Eye Gouge	Head
Gashed Thigh/Crushed Hip	Leg
Gut Wound/Ruptured Spleen	Torso
Nicked Artery/Gushing Artery	Other
Seeping Wound/Gangrenous Wound	Other
Sprained Ankle/Splintered Kneecap	Leg
Sprained Wrist/Broken Arm	Arm
Wrenched Back/Cracked Spine	Torso
Blackouts/Fainting Spells	Other

Arm Injury	Strength
Trigger: You roll the maximum result on a damage die and choose to keep it.	
Success: The damaging effect deals extra damage equal to 5 + one-half your level to a single target.	
Failure: You take a -2 penalty to attack rolls until the end of the encounter.	

Head Injury	Wisdom
Trigger: You take your first turn in an encounter without delaying for an enemy, and you hit with your first attack.	
Success: You gain 5 temporary hit points per tier.	
Failure: You are dazed until the end of your next turn.	

Leg Injury	Dexterity
Trigger: You are subjected to forced movement while slowed by an injury.	
Success: You negate the forced movement.	
Failure: You fall prone after the forced movement.	

Torso Injury	Constitution
Trigger: You use an immediate action to make an attack.	
Success: You gain a +2 power bonus to the attack roll.	
Failure: You are stunned until the end of your next turn after the attack is resolved.	

Other Injury

Constitution

Trigger: You take damage from an attack.

Success: You can spend a healing surge.

Failure: Your healing surge value is reduced by one-half your level until you take a short rest.

VARIANT: RECOVERING FROM INJURIES

Characters can attempt to recover from their injuries at the end of each extended rest. An injured character makes an Endurance check for each injury. Use a moderate DC of the character's level. On a success, the character reduces the severity of a major injury to minor, or if the severity was already minor, the character recovers from the injury (discarding the card). On a failure, the severity of the injury remains unchanged.

A character who has training in the Heal skill can use that skill to attempt to aid an ally's Endurance check for the purpose of recovering from an injury (using the rules for aiding another). A character can aid only one ally per extended rest and must make a separate Heal check for each injury.

Characters can also use the Remove Affliction ritual to treat an injury. The penalty to the Heal check equals the injured character's level if treating a minor injury, or the injured character's level + 5 if treating a major injury. If successful in either case, the character recovers from the injury (discarding the card).

Regardless of whether a character recovers from an injury naturally or with magical aid, telltale scars often remain. Retired adventurers bear such marks with rueful pride; each scar tells a story.

Changing the Pace

The recovery rules assume that you're running an ongoing game in which the characters follow a typical adventuring routine, tackling at least a few encounters during each day of game time. You can choose to adapt injuries to work with different play formats, too.

If you're running a single delve-style session, in which the party is unlikely to take an extended rest, allow the players to make their recovery checks after each short rest instead. A character cannot attempt to recover from a wound sustained during the encounter he or she just finished, though. That character has to suffer through it for at least one fight!

If you're running a campaign where the action is spread out over the course of days or weeks, you can draw out the recovery process. Depending on the time frames involved, you might have the players make recovery checks once a week rather than every day, or require that they succeed on multiple recovery rolls before reducing the severity of an injury.

About the Author

Jeffrey Ludwig has never TPKed a party with a crushing walls trap. Nor has he driven them to a watery grave. The incident with the cave bear was a statistical fluke, and he staunchly denies having turned one player's favorite character into an undead. Twice. This article is his first contribution to D&D INSIDER™ . . . and character longevity.

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MINOR

NICKED ARTERY

While you are bloodied, you regain only half the normal number of hit points from healing effects.

Whenever you take damage in an encounter, you are considered to be bloodied for that encounter, regardless of your hit point total, until you are restored to maximum hit points.

GUSHING ARTERY

MAJOR

MINOR

CRACKED RIB

Whenever you take an immediate or opportunity action, you take a -2 penalty to saving throws until the end of your next turn.

You are dazed during the first turn of each encounter. If you are allowed a saving throw to end this effect, you take a -2 penalty to that roll.

SUCKING CHEST WOUND

MAJOR

MINOR

WRENCHED BACK

Whenever you make a Strength- or Dexterity-based attack, skill check, or ability check, you can either take a -2 penalty to the roll or grant combat advantage until the start of your next turn.

Whenever you fail a Strength- or Dexterity-based skill check or ability check, or miss with a Strength- or Dexterity-based attack, you are immobilized until the end of your next turn.

CRACKED SPINE

MAJOR

MINOR

BLACKOUTS

Whenever you make an Intelligence-, Wisdom-, or Charisma-based attack, skill check, or ability check, unless you choose to take a -2 penalty to the roll, you cannot use immediate actions until the start of your next turn.

Whenever you fail an Intelligence-, Wisdom-, or Charisma-based skill check or ability check, or miss with an Intelligence-, Wisdom-, or Charisma-based attack, make a saving throw. On a failure, you fall unconscious until the start of your next turn or until you take damage.

FAINTING SPELLS

MAJOR

MINOR

FACE SLASH

All creatures have partial concealment against you. You can spend a minor action on your turn to ignore the effects of this minor injury until the start of your next turn.

While bloodied, whenever you take damage from an attack, you are blinded until the start of your next turn.

EYE GOUGE

MAJOR

MINOR

MAJOR

